



When Odysseus left for the war, his wife Penelope had taken over running the kingdom. When he didn't return from Troy for seven years, the kings from nearby lands assumed he was dead and they came to beg Penelope to marry them.

Penelope believed that Odysseus was still alive, though, and she made a plan to delay the suitors. She gathered them in a room and said, "I will choose a new husband, but only once I have woven a shroud for Odysseus's father, Laertes, who is growing old. Once it is finished, I will marry again."

The shroud was a special cloth used to bury the dead. Ordinarily, this task would not take long, but although Penelope spent every day weaving in front of the eager suitors, at night she would sneak back and undo all of her work.

*In this way, Penelope managed to fool the suitors for three full years.*

When Odysseus finally landed on the shores of Ithaca, he was alone, as he had lost every member of his crew on his travels. Waiting for him on the beach was the goddess Athena, who wanted to help him. "What has become of my kingdom?" he asked, and Athena told him about the suitors in his palace.

Odysseus was furious. "Do not worry," Athena said, "I have a plan." Using her powers, Athena disguised Odysseus as a beggar, so that no one would recognize him.